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Progress

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Explore
Saved
Progress
History
More

in: Sanskrit, Poetic form

Sanskrit prosody

EDIT

See Vedic meter for meter in Vedic Sanskrit.

Versification in Classical Sanskrit poetry is of three kinds.[1]

1. Syllabic verse (**akṣaravṛtta**): meters depend on the number of syllables in a verse, with relative freedom in the distribution of light and heavy syllables. This style is derived from older Vedic forms, and found in the great epics, the Mahabharata and the Ramayana.
2. Syllabo-quantitative verse (**varnavṛtta**): meters depend on syllable count, but the light-heavy patterns are fixed.
3. Quantitative verse (**mātrāvṛtta**): meters depend on duration, where each verse-line has a fixed number of morae, usually grouped in sets of four.

Standard traditional works on

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Saved
Progress
History
More

Vṛttaratnākara. The most exhaustive compilations, such as the modern ones by Patwardhan and Velankar contain over 600 metres. This is a substantially larger repertoire than in any other metrical tradition.[2]

Contents

1. Elements of prosody
1.1. Light and heavy syllables
1.2. Gaṇa
1.2.1. An example
1.2.2. A mnemonic
1.2.3. Comparison
2. Akṣarachanda
3. Epic poetry
4. Moraic poetry
5. Notes
6. References
7. See also
8. External links

Elements of prosody

Light and heavy syllables

In most of Sanskrit poetry the primary determinant of a meter is the number of syllables in a unit of verse, called the **pāda** ("foot", not to be confused with the "foot" of Western prosody). Meters of the same length are distinguished by the pattern of **laghu** ("light") and **guru**

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The rules distinguishing **laghu** and **guru** syllables are the same as are specified in Vedic texts such as the Pratisakhyas. They can be summarized as:[3][4]

1. A syllable is *laghu* only if its vowel is **hrasva** ("short") and followed by at most one consonant before another vowel is encountered.
2. A syllable with an *anusvara* ('ṃ') or a *visarga* ('ḥ') is always *guru*.
3. All other syllables are *guru*, either because the vowel is **dīrgha** ("long"), or because the *hrasva* vowel is followed by a consonant cluster.
4. The *hrasva* vowels are the short monophthongs: 'a', 'i', 'u', 'ṛ' and 'ḷ'
5. All other vowels are *dīrgha*: 'ā', 'ī', 'ū', 'ṝ', 'e', 'ai', 'o' and 'au'. (Note that, morphologically, the last four vowels are actually the diphthongs 'ai', 'āi', 'au' and 'āu', as the rules of sandhi in Sanskrit make clear. So, while an original 'ai', for example, had been shortened to an 'e' sound in practice,

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Progress
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metrically. The original short 'e' and short 'o' sounds had already been assimilated into short 'a' in the Proto-Indo-Iranian period of the language.[5])

For measurement by morae, laghu syllables count as one unit, and guru syllables as two units.[6] The standard unit of grouping, analogous to the "foot" of Western prosody, is four morae (four laghus, two gurus, or a guru and two laghus).

Gaṇa

Gaṇa (Sanskrit, "group") is the technical term for the pattern of light and heavy syllables in a sequence of three. It is used in treatises on **Sanskrit prosody** to describe meters, according to a method first propounded in Pingala's *chandaḥśāstra*.

Pingala's method described any meter as a sequence of **gaṇa**s, or triplets of syllables, plus the excess, if any, as single units. There being eight possible patterns of light and heavy syllables in a sequence of three, this scheme called for ten descriptive elements in all. With each of these ten, Pingala associated a letter, allowing the meter to be described compactly as an

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Saved
Progress
History
More

- The units:[8]
  - **l**: a "light" syllable (L), called *laghu*
  - **g**: a "heavy" syllable (H), called *guru*
- The gaṇas:[9]
  - **m** : H-H-H, called *ma-gaṇa*
  - **y** : L-H-H, called *ya-gaṇa*
  - **r** : H-L-H, called *ra-gaṇa*
  - **s** : L-L-H, called *sa-gaṇa*
  - **t** : H-H-L, called *ta-gaṇa*
  - **j** : L-H-L, called *ja-gaṇa*
  - **bh**: H-L-L, called *bha-gaṇa*
  - **n** : L-L-L, called *na-gaṇa*

Pingala's order of the gaṇas, viz. **m-y-r-s-t-j-bh-n**, corresponds to a standard enumeration in binary, when the three syllables in each gaṇa are read right-to-left with H=0 and L=1.

An example

The definition of the meter Vasantatilakā given by Kedāra in his *Vṛttaratnākara* is

```
uktā vasantatilakā
tabhajā jagau gaḥ
```

which can be decoded as

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t bh j j g g = H-H-L-H-L-L-L-H-L-L-H-L-H-H

Note that Kedāra's definition is itself an example of the meter.[10]

A mnemonic

The word **yamātārājabhānasalagāḥ** (or **yamātārājabhānasalagaṃ**), invented by medieval commentators, is a mnemonic for Pingala's gaṇas, using the vowels "a" and "ā" for light and heavy syllables respectively with the letters of his scheme. In the form without a grammatical ending, ***yamātārājabhānasalagā*** is self-descriptive, where the structure of each *gaṇa* is shown by its own syllable and the two following it:[11]

- **ya-gaṇa**: ya-mā-tā = L-H-H
- **ma-gaṇa**: mā-tā-rā = H-H-H
- **ta-gaṇa**: tā-rā-ja = H-H-L
- **ra-gaṇa**: rā-ja-bhā = H-L-H
- **ja-gaṇa**: ja-bhā-na = L-H-L
- **bha-gaṇa**: bhā-na-sa = H-L-L
- **na-gaṇa**: na-sa-la = L-L-L
- **sa-gaṇa**: sa-la-gā = L-L-H

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the light "la" and heavy "gā" unit syllables of the full scheme.

The truncated version obtained by dropping the last two syllables, viz. **yamātārājabhānasa**, can be read cyclically (i.e., wrapping around to the front). It is an example of a De Bruijn sequence.

Comparison

The gaṇas are not the same as prosodic feet in Greek or Latin poetry, although there is a correspondence (m-y-r-s-t-j-bh-n = molossus, bacchius, cretic, anapest, antibacchius, amphibrach, dactyl, choreus). The difference is that the gaṇas are analytic devices only, and do not indicate internal structure as "feet" do. For instance, a phalaecian verse consisting of a spondee, a dactyl and three trochees would be analysed as m-s-j-g-l (i.e. a molossus, an anapest, an amphibrach and a trochee); similarly a sapphic verse as r-t-j-g-l (cretic, antibacchius, amphibrach and trochee). [12]

Akṣarachanda

Most of classical Sanskrit poetry is of the varṇavṛtta type, also called akṣarachanda. Stanzas are quatrains of four pādas

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completely specified. In some cases, pairs of pādas may be scanned together as the hemistichs of a couplet.[13] It is then normal for the pādas comprising a pair to have different structures, to complement each other aesthetically. Otherwise the four pādas of a stanza will have the same structure.

Epic poetry

While the Mahabharata has various types of versification, an overwhelming proportion of the stanzas (all but about 0.2%) are akṣaravṛtta (free syllabic). Within this majority, 95% are shlokas of the anustubh type and the rest are tristubhs.[14]

Moraic poetry

- **mātrāchanda**:[15]
  1. **puṣpitāgrā**
  2. **aparavaktra**
  3. **vaitālīya**
  4. **mātrāsamaka**
- **gaṇachanda**:[16]
  1. **āryā**
  2. **āryāgīti**
  3. **upagīti**

Notes

1. Deo, p.5
2. Deo, p. 3
3. Coulson, p.21
4. Muller & Macdonell, Appendix II

More

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6. Muller and Macdonell, loc.cit.
7. Pingala, *chandaḥśāstra*, 1.1-10
8. Pingala CS 1.9-10, in order
9. Pingala CS, 1.1-8, in order
10. Coulson, p.253
11. Coulson, p.253ff
12. Colebrooke, p.64
13. Hopkins, p.194. (This is typical for the shloka).
14. Hopkins, p.192
15. Hopkins, p.193
16. Hopkins, loc. cit.

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- Colebrooke, H.T. (1873). "On Sanskrit and Prakrit Poetry". *Miscellaneous Essays*. **2**. London: Trübner and Co.. pp. 57–146.
- Coulson, Michael (1976). *Teach Yourself Sanskrit*. Teach Yourself Books. Hodder and Stoughton.
- Hopkins, E.W. (1901). "Epic versification". *The Great Epic of India*. New York: C. Scribner's Sons. pp. 191–362. LCCN (http://lccn.loc.gov/01012892)
- ***PDF (http://www.buddhanet-de.net/ancient-buddhist-texts/Textual-Studies/Prosody-Articles/Macdonell-***

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Indische Studien. **8**. Leipzig.

See also

- Pingala

External links

- Sanskrit metre recognizer (http://sanskrit.sai.uni-heidelberg.de/Chanda/) ("This is a test version. Only varNa-vRttas are now recognized.")
- Recordings of recitation: H. V. Nagaraja Rao (ORI, Mysore) (http://home.wlu.edu/~lubint/texts/index.htm), Ashwini Deo (http://pantheon.yale.edu/~asd49/meters.html), Ram Karan Sharma (http://www.mywhatever.com/sanskrit/chant/index.html)
- "Al-Biruni and the Arithmetical Sequence of the Sanskrit Gaṇas" (http://www.new.dli.ernet.in/rawdataupload/upload/insa/INSA_1/20005b59_259.pdf)

cs:Védská metrika hi:भारतीय छन्दशास्त्र id:Chanda pt:Métrica védica ru:Чхандас

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